

WHY DO I MATTER AND WHO CARES?

When we are experiencing depression, we often feel worthless. We may become convinced that our lives don't matter and no one understands or cares how we feel, or even that others would be better off without us. These feelings and perceptions are symptoms of depression, but they aren't accurate, and they can be dangerous. This exercise will help you get a true picture that your life matters and others truly care about you, and help you create a plan to form stronger connections with people to whom you are important and get their emotional support.

1. First, think of things that others have done for you that have been helpful and important in your life. These others may have been family members, friends, teachers, faith leaders, employers, team coaches, or anyone else who has really helped you along the way. Please give three examples, describing who they were, what they did for you, and why it mattered. _____

2. Now reflect on whether you've done similar things for others. Name three people whose lives you've touched in a good way, and describe what you did. _____

3. What do you think these people would say if someone asked them whether your life is important to them? _____

4. Ask three other people (friends or family members) the following question, and record their responses here: "If I were going to do something to help other people, what are some abilities I have or things I could do that would be helpful, and who could I help?" _____

5. Please use this space to create a simple plan to start doing one thing for other people during the next two weeks, either based on a suggestion in response to question 4 or to another idea. _____
6. What people do you believe, at this moment, really understand you and care about your feelings? _____
7. Please think of someone you see in meetings, or in your faith community, or in another setting who seems to have a lot of life experiences like your own and is a wise and caring person. It's best to choose a person, like a program sponsor, for whom you feel respect but no romantic attraction. Your task during the next week is to approach this person and tell them that you would like to talk and get some feedback on issues you're working on. Set a time and place when you can talk for at least an hour without interruptions. When you talk, tell this person about what's happening in your life and how you feel about it, and ask whether they have ever felt the same way. Record the other person's responses and how you felt after the conversation here. _____
8. The last part of this assignment is to create a plan to reach out for emotional support when you need it, as we all do sometimes. Please list five people you can talk to if you are feeling troubled, confused, or discouraged, and write about how you will approach each of them, in advance, to ask for this support.

Name**How I Will Ask for Support**

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

9. What ways could a Higher Power assist you in overcoming the problem of suicidal thinking, hopelessness, and feeling as if you do not matter to others? You may have heard others in 12-step meetings or your group treatment sessions talk about this. What have they said is one way you can challenge your own self-talk about not mattering? _____

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.